At 69, the multi-hyphenate Mallika Sarabhai is certain of one thing: she isn't interested in legacies. Over a Zoom video call from Ahmedabad, she talks to us about her favourite Sufi poem, 'The Conference of the Birds'. "It's a metaphorical journey that a set of birds undertake when they are told they have to find their king, the Simorgh. During this long, arduous journey, one of the valleys they cross is the Valley of Realisation, which underlines how small all of us are; how one is just a blink in time," she says. "And if one is a blink, why should one think of legacy?"

It seems odd to hear that from someone who belongs to a family of legacy. Sarabhai was born to legendary classical dancer Mrinalini Sarabhai and Vikram Sarabhai, the Indian physicist and space scientist responsible for pioneering space research and nuclear power in the country. In fact, Sarabhai's own legacy cultivated in over four decades of public life feels all-encompassing: an accomplished dancer, she has also immersed herself in an illustrious acting career, starring in several regional and international productions—including playing Draupadi in Peter Brook's stage adaptation of *The Mahabharata*—while directing, writing and producing on the side.

If that wasn't enough, Sarabhai went on to serve as a columnist for numerous publications; she dipped her feet in Indian politics when she campaigned as an independent candidate against the BJP's prime ministerial candidate L.K. Advani in the 2009 general elections, and continued to employ arts as a way of harnessing social change. Now, with *In Free Fall: My Experiments with Living*, a book meant to trace the arc of an artist's career through the progress of her mind and body, Sarabhai has gone through yet another transformation as a newly-minted author.

The idea of *In Free Fall: My Experiments with Living*, which Sarabhai calls a "passion memoir", came to her in 2020. But it really emerged from the questions people have constantly asked her over the years: "How do you stay fit? How do you look the way you do? How do you have so much energy to dance like a 16-year-old?" Being locked down alone in the sprawling Darpana campus—the school for performing arts established by her late parents—was enough of a trigger for Sarabhai to start summarising her "adventurous alternative health journey".

Much of the book revolves around Sarabhai's varied attempts to exercise control over her body. In frank prose, she details the extent of her body image issues that led to a period in her life when she found it impossible to eat rice guilt-free. In her pursuit of being thin, Sarabhai suffered from bouts of anorexia and bulimia when she put her body through rigorous dieting fads. Eventually, she ditched all that to find her own path of mindful eating. The dissonance between Sarabhai's assured public image and her deteriorating private self sometimes feels like an apt illumination of the many sacrifices artists make for their art.

"Very early on in my performing career, I had decided that total honesty was the only way to deal with things," she says, explaining the reason behind making her struggles with eating public. "I think talking about my vulnerabilities, the pain I felt and the adjustments I had to make to envision a different life for myself could all possibly give readers the

Sarabhai writes that dance discovered her, and in the process, it let her discover unknown facets of herself



IN FREE FALL: MY EXPERIMENTS WITH LIVING
by Mallika Sarabhai
SPEAKING TIGER
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PASSING THE MANTLE
Mallika Sarabhai (right) with her mother Mrinalini; in the background is her father Vikram Sarabhai's portrait on the wall